

**MY FAVORITE THINGS IN LIFE DON'T COST
ANY MONEY. IT'S REALLY CLEAR THAT THE
MOST PRECIOUS RESOURCE WE ALL
HAVE IS TIME.**

STEVE JOBS, CO-FOUNDER OF APPLE INC.

All work and no play...

The decisions we make about work are economic decisions. The time we have is a resource that can be used in many ways. Some of it's already taken up with things we absolutely have to do, such as sleeping and eating. The rest, roughly two-thirds of our time, is available for either work or leisure and to lead a full and happy life. It's important to find a balance. For many people in poor countries, the choices they have are limited, and in order to get the necessities of life they must work long hours for little pay, leaving them with neither the time nor money for leisure. But in developed countries, most people choose their lifestyle and the work–life balance that suits them.

Is it worth it?

Of course, choosing what work to do depends on how much money we can earn, and whether that will pay for everything that we want as well as need. But working also involves a large proportion of our time. Achieving the work–life balance we want is an example of what economists call “[opportunity cost](#)”—this means measuring the value of things we want by what we are prepared to give up for them. The income from a job is valuable to us, but then so is our leisure time. If we work more, we may have more income, but this comes at the cost of less leisure time. On the other hand, if